

1. Evaluate whether the First World War was primarily caused by popular nationalism or by the decisions of government leaders.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a historically defensible thesis or claim that establishes a line of reasoning.
- Describe a broader historical context relevant to the prompt.
- Support an argument in response to the prompt using at least four documents.
- Use at least one additional piece of specific historical evidence (beyond that found in the documents) relevant to an argument about the prompt.
- For at least two documents, explain how or why the document's point of view, purpose, historical situation, and/or audience is relevant to an argument.
- Demonstrate a complex understanding of a historical development related to the prompt through sophisticated argumentation and/or effective use of evidence.

Document 1

Source: Constitution of the Black Hand, a secret organization devoted to liberating Serbs living under Austro-Hungarian rule, Belgrade, Serbia, 1911

“Article 4. In order to carry into effect its task, the organization will do the following things:

(1) The Black Hand will exercise its influence over all the government institutions in Serbia and also over all the levels of the State and over the entire social life in it....

(3) Beyond the frontiers, it will fight with all means against all enemies of this idea.

(4) It will maintain friendly relations with all the States, nations, organizations, and individual persons who sympathize with Serbia and the Serbian people.

(5) It will give every assistance to those nations and organizations who are fighting for their own national liberation and unification.”

Document 2

Source: Henri Massis and Alfred de Tarde, “The Young People of Today,” article in a Paris newspaper based on an opinion poll conducted among male students in elite educational institutions, 1912

“Consider something even more significant. The most cultivated elite young people declare that they find warfare an aesthetic ideal of energy and strength. They believe that ‘France needs heroism in order to live.’ How many times in the last two years have we heard: ‘Better war than this eternal waiting!’ There is no bitterness in this, but rather a secret hope.

War! The word has taken on a sudden glamor. It is a youthful word, wholly new, adorned with that seduction which the eternal aggressive instinct has revived in the hearts of men. These young men imagine war to have all the beauty with which they are in love and of which they have been deprived by ordinary life. Above all, war in their eyes, is the occasion for the most noble of human virtues.... For such men, fired by patriotic faith and the cult of military virtues, only the occasion for heroism is lacking.”

Document 3

Source: Jules Cambon, French Ambassador to Germany, report to the French Minister for Foreign Affairs, on a new German military spending bill, March 1913

“The debate about the financial means by which Germany intends to pay for these new military measures is the sole cause of the government’s delay in proposing the measures to the legislature. In spite of the patriotism with which the rich classes pretend to accept the sacrifices asked of them, they are none the less dissatisfied with the financial measures which have been announced, and they feel that a new tax imposed in times of peace creates a dangerous precedent for the future.

[As a result of these concerns], the Imperial German government is constantly rousing patriotic sentiment. Every day Kaiser Wilhelm delights to revive memories of 1813.¹ Yesterday evening a military parade went through the streets of Berlin, and speeches were delivered in which the present situation was compared to that of a hundred years ago. The trend of public opinion will find an echo in the speeches which will be delivered next month in the Reichstag,² and I fear that the German Chancellor himself will be forced to allude in his statements to the relations of France and Germany.”

1: a reference to the expulsion of French armies from Germany by Prussia and its allies during the Napoleonic Wars

2: German legislature

Document 4

Source: Leopold Berchtold, Austro-Hungarian Minister for Foreign Affairs, letter of instruction to the Austrian ambassador to Serbia, July 22, 1914

“Your Excellency will present the following note to the Royal Government [of Serbia] tomorrow afternoon:

The history of the past few years, and particularly the painful events of the 28th of June,¹ have proved the existence of a subversive movement in Serbia, whose object is to separate certain portions of territory from the Austro-Hungarian Monarchy. This movement, which came into being under the very eyes of the Serbian Government, subsequently found expression outside of the territory of the Kingdom in acts of terrorism, in a number of attempts at assassination, and in murders.

It is clear from the statements and confessions of the perpetrators of the assassination on the 28th of June, that the murder at Sarajevo was conceived at Belgrade, that the murderers received the weapons and the bombs with which they were equipped by Serbian officers and officials who belonged to a Serbian nationalist organization, and, finally, that the dispatch of the criminals and of their weapons to Bosnia was arranged and effected under the conduct of Serbian frontier authorities.”

1: a reference to the assassination of Austrian Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo

Document 5

Source: Telegrams between Tsar Nicholas II of Russia and Kaiser Wilhelm II of Germany, 1914. The two rulers were cousins and grandchildren of Great Britain’s Queen Victoria.

Nicholas to Wilhelm, July 31, 1914

“I thank you heartily for your mediation which begins to give one hope that all may yet end peacefully. It is technically impossible to stop our military preparations which were obligatory owing to Austria’s mobilization of its armies. We are far from wishing war. As long as our negotiations with Austria on Serbia’s account are taking place my troops shall not make any provocative action. I give you my solemn word for this. I put all my trust in God’s mercy and hope in your successful mediation in Vienna for the welfare of our countries and for the peace of Europe.

Your affectionate Nicky”

Wilhelm to Nicholas, August 1, 1914

“Thanks for your telegram. I yesterday pointed out to your government the only way by which war may be avoided. Although I requested an answer at noon today, no telegram from my ambassador conveying an answer from your Government has reached me as yet. I therefore have been obliged to mobilize my army.

Immediate, affirmative, clear, and unmistakable answer from your government is the only way to avoid endless misery. Until I have received this answer alas, I am unable to discuss the subject of your telegram. As a matter of fact, I must request you to immediately order your troops on no account to commit the slightest act of trespassing over our frontiers.

Willy”

Document 6

Source: Jacques Moreau, professional photographer, women seeing off soldiers going to the front, Paris, August 1914



Archives Larousse, Paris, France/Bridgeman Images

Moreau took this picture just before he was called up for duty.

Document 7

Source: Rosa Luxemburg, German revolutionary socialist, pamphlet written from prison, 1915

“The scene has changed fundamentally. The six weeks’ march to Paris [promised by the German high command in 1914] has grown into a world drama. Mass slaughter has become the tiresome and monotonous business of the day and the end is no closer.

Gone is the euphoria. Gone the patriotic noise in the streets. Gone the swaying crowds in the coffee shops with ear-deafening patriotic songs surging ever higher. Gone the transformation of whole city neighborhoods into mobs ready to denounce [suspected foreign spies], to shout hurrah and to induce delirium in themselves by means of wild rumors.

The spectacle is over. The trains full of troops are no longer accompanied by women fainting from pure happiness. The soldiers no longer greet the people from the windows of the trains with joyous smiles. Carrying their packs, they quietly trot along the streets where the public goes about its daily business with unhappy faces.”